the despatch of the note of protest to the Soviet government in September 1921 over its agreement violation. When the Soviet reply came back, it unsurprisingly contained a denial of all that the British government had accused it.[141] Unfortunately for Curzon, it turned out that much of the evidence on which the note of protest had been based was actually rather shaky and that which was reliable was too sensitive to be made public.[142] The foreign secretary was said to be 'appalled' at the situation in which he had now been placed. Not only had his objections to the Soviet trade agreement been overruled in the first place, but now he faced 'the odium of having made public charges which I cannot sustain'.[143]

It could be postulated, then, that one reason the Home government was so stubborn over the Afghan negotiations was because, when faced with failure and humiliation elsewhere, it could not cope with the same results in Afghanistan. Much like with Persia, when the Afghans appeared to be rejecting the British proffer of friendship in the form of the exclusive treaty, London became intractable. This time, however, it was not simply Curzon proving difficult. Montagu was adamant that more could be extracted from Kabul than the Indian government would gain with the pis aller treaty. That the secretary of state was being influenced by the foreign secretary is clear from the statement noted above regarding Curzon's agreement with his course of action. Montagu had taken Curzon's side against Chelmsford when it came to the Persian agreement of 1919 – now he appeared to be doing the same over Afghanistan. And yet, considering his mistakes in Persia, it is surprising that the foreign secretary still appeared to command such authority over his colleagues. The Times newspaper certainly recognised the seeming contradiction here, criticising Curzon for his involvement in Afghan affairs:

The Anglo-Persian Agreement fiasco should convince the British Cabinet, despite the influence of Lord Curzon, whose great knowledge of the East is out of date and tends to confirm his pro-consular attitude – an attitude unjustified now, when modern notions of self-determination have spread even to the pastoral ruggedness of Afghanistan.[144]